



NTop as a Network Diagnostics Tool

The NTop tool is a network traffic monitoring tool that shows network usage, similar to what the popular `top` UNIX command does. This article explains its utility while troubleshooting network problems.

rganisations face various types of network problems, which result in inaccessible devices, degradation of performance, intermittent disconnections, etc. These can be broadly classified into:

- Network hardware failure: this includes faulty passive devices (information outlets, patch panels), improper cabling and crimping, and faulty active devices (switches, Ethernet cards).
- Network configuration problems: this includes improper configuration of protocols, and installation of unwanted protocols.
- Malicious code: the presence of worms/viruses on the network may cause performance to drop.

Table 1 details some possible reasons for network-related problems.

To troubleshoot network problems from scratch, you would typically start by checking the network hardware—study the network diagram; and physically check the network cabling, network cable crossovers over electrical cables, crimping quality, quality of IOs (Information Outlets), switches, routers, and practically all hardware being used for the network. It is well and good if the problem lies in hardware, since the tracking is reasonably straightforward.

However, troubleshooting problems related to network configuration/malicious code can turn really nasty and result in a long-drawn-out battle. This is because of the variety of